India's first PM Jawaharlal Nehru, an ardent proponent of non-alignment as a foreign policy principle, Afghanistan's military demands could potentially become an irritant in India's quest for peace with Pakistan.[19] Yet, Nehru the realist worried that Afghanistan's goodwill for India could not to be taken for granted, and directed intelligence chief B. N. Mullik to remain vigilant lest Kabul gravitate towards Pakistan (by joining the World Muslim Federation that Islamabad championed).[20] Economic tools were to be used to this effect, with the caveat that Afghanistan did not become dependent on Indian aid. For 'generosity' as Nehru noted, 'is a risky business in the long run'.[21] Peaceful resolution of Afghanistan-Pakistan bilateral disputes was advocated.

In this context, the 1955 Asian-African Conference for International Order, or the Bandung Conference, offered an international framework within which India and Afghanistan developed their bilateral ties.[22] Envisioned as a platform for Asian and African resurgence against colonialism, the conference articulated an alternative world order and demonstrated 'neutrality' in a bipolar world. Concerned about the fallout of an arms race in the subcontinent, both India and Afghanistan used the non-alignment plank to criticise Cold War binaries. It was also meant to challenge Pakistan's siding with the US after Islamabad signed the Mutual Defence Agreement with Washington in May 1954, joined the Southeast Treaty Organisation (SEATO) in September 1954, and the Central Treaty Organisation (CENTO) in 1955.[23] An internationalist strategy of criticising countries that entered into military pacts with big powers sought to isolate Pakistan in Asia and Africa. The strategy failed, and more so for Afghanistan where the sentiment for an independent Pashtunistan broiled: a sentiment that had kept Kabul from voting in favour of recognising Pakistan as an independent country in 1947. It is not surprising then that throughout the 1950s Pakistani media charged Afghanistan and India of working together to 'capture' Pakistan in a pincer attack.[24] India categorically denied such claims as 'false' and 'insulting both to India and Afghanistan'.[25] Regardless, the theme of Indo-Afghan collaboration to undermine Pakistan's security and sovereignty became entrenched in Pakistan's national security discourse.

Indian 'Anschluss'